absolutely no one to look after them, or to make offerings . . .many [monasteries] were left undamaged'. Nalanda was then patronized by the Buddhist king of Magadh. He ruled from his capital at Bodh Gaya and had apparently survived the Turks' onslaught and regional hegemony. (Generations of these new arrivals and their descendants were seen primarily in ethnic terms as *Turushka*s, or Turks, and secondarily as Muslims.)

Rather than a dramatic final end, Dharmasvamin's biography and other historical sources suggest a drawn-out phase of decay and depopulation of Nalanda. This was driven by many factors, including: (1) sharp funding cuts under the Palas and from other donors; (2) the Sena Dynasty's persecution of monks over many decades; (3) sporadic attacks over many decades by roving bands of soldiers in the army of Bakhtiar Khilji's descendants, who, in their bid for independence, were themselves often at war with Iltumish and others of the Delhi Sultanate (when they were finally reined in, Nalanda and Bihar fell back under the Delhi Sultanate, c. 1250).

But Nalanda's story doesn't end there. An early eighteenth-century Tibetan history of Buddhism claims that Nalanda was repaired after the Turkish raids and continued at least until a conflict (no date given) erupted with some Brahmin mendicants, who caused a 'great conflagration which consumed Ratnadodhi, one of the [three] libraries of Nalanda'.[39] True or not, this is apparently the last mention of Nalanda in our historical sources.

What, then, is the truth of Nalanda's demise? While these historical sources don't rule out a devastating attack on Nalanda by Bakhtiar Khilji, they don't provide clear evidence for it either. Why then do so many claim that Khilji ravaged Nalanda—and the Turks destroyed Buddhism in India—when there's a far more persuasive web of reasons for their demise? Historian Johan Elverskog blames it on the seduction of 'a clear-cut narrative with good guys and bad', one that 'avoids entirely the complex shades of gray that most often color the messy fabric of history'.[40]

Another complicating factor was British Indology. Building on a long-standing European antipathy towards Islam, the British emphasized 'Muslim barbarity and misrule in order to justify the introduction of their supposedly more humane and rational form of colonial rule'.[41] The British contrasted the darkness of Muslim rule with their own, 'when the full light